What is an Experimental Survey?

- An **experimental survey** is a type of survey that **tests cause-and-effect relationships** by manipulating one or more variables while keeping other conditions constant.
- Unlike regular surveys that simply collect opinions, **experimental surveys introduce changes** and observe how people respond.

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Features of Experimental Surveys

- Control Groups
- Random Assignment
- Manipulation of Variables
- Comparison of Results

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Types of Experimental Surveys

- **A/B Testing Surveys**
  - Two versions of a question or scenario are shown to different groups.
  - **Example:** A company tests **two different email subject lines** to see which gets more clicks.
- **Randomized Controlled Surveys**
  - Participants are **randomly assigned** to groups that receive different versions of a question or scenario.
  - **Example:** A researcher tests **two different political messages** to see which gains more support.
- **Factorial Surveys**
  - Multiple variables are changed simultaneously to see their combined effect.
  - **Example:** A survey tests the **impact of price and product quality** on purchase decisions.

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Steps to Perform an Experimental Survey

- Step1: Define the Research Question
  - **Example:**
    "Which email subject line gets more customer engagement?"
- Step 2: Identify the Independent & Dependent Variables
- Step 3: Divide Participants into Groups
- Step 4: Collect & Compare Responses
- Step 5: Analyze & Apply Results

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Case Study

- **Step 1: Choose a Research Question**
  - *How does question phrasing influence students' opinions on social media usage?*
- **Step 2: Select Participants and Divide Groups**
  - **Group A (Control Group):** Answers the neutral question.
  - **Group B (Experimental Group):** Answers the biased question.
- **Step 3: Collect Responses**
- **Step 4: Compare Results**
- **Step 5: Analysis and Discussion**

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What is a Non-Experimental Survey?

- A **non-experimental survey** is a research method used to collect information without manipulating any variables.
- Unlike experimental surveys, which test cause-and-effect relationships, non-experimental surveys are used to **describe trends, opinions, and behaviors** without introducing changes.

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Features of Non-Experimental Surveys

- No **manipulation** of variables
- No **control or experimental groups**
- Used to **describe, analyze, and compare responses**
- Common in **social sciences, market research, and public opinion polls**

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Types of Non-Experimental Surveys

- **Descriptive Surveys**
  - **Example:** *A university conducts a survey to find out how many students use online learning resources.*
- **Cross-Sectional Surveys**
  - **Example:** *A survey asks different age groups about their favorite social media platform in 2024.*
- **Correlational Surveys**
  - **Example:** *A survey studies the link between screen time and sleep patterns in teenagers*

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How to Perform a Non-Experimental Survey

- Step 1: Define the Research Question
- Step 2: Choose the Survey Type
- Step 3: Design the Survey Questions
- Step 4: Collect Data from Participants
- Step 5: Analyze & Report Findings

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Ethical Considerations in Surveys

- Informed Consent
- Confidentiality
- Common Ethical Issues in Survey Research

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Informed Consent

- **Participants must agree to participate with full knowledge of the survey's purpose.**
- **How to Obtain Consent:**
  - Clearly state objectives.
  - Provide contact details for inquiries.
  - Allow participants to opt out.

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What should be included in a consent form?

1. **Purpose of the Study** – Why the research is being conducted and what the expected outcomes are.
2. **Data Usage** – How their personal and medical data will be collected, stored, and analyzed.
3. **Confidentiality & Privacy** – Measures taken to protect their identity and ensure data security.
4. **Potential Risks & Benefits** – Any possible side effects, discomforts, or advantages of participating.
5. **Voluntary Participation** – Assurance that participation is completely **optional**, and they can **withdraw at any time** without penalty.

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Example

- A hospital is conducting a study on a new diabetes treatment.
- Before joining, each patient must sign a consent form explaining that:
- Their blood sugar levels will be tracked for **six months**.
- Their data will be **anonymized** and shared with researchers.
- They may experience **mild side effects** but can withdraw at any point.
- **Why is this important?**
  - Informed consent ensures **ethical research** by giving participants full transparency, protecting their rights, and maintaining trust in scientific studies.

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Confidentiality & Anonymity

- **Confidentiality:** Data is private but linked to individuals.
- **Anonymity:** No personally identifiable information is collected.

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Why Is Anonymity Important in Sensitive Topic Surveys?

1. **Encourages Honest Responses**
   - People are more likely to **share their true opinions and experiences** if they know their identities won't be revealed.
   - **Example:** In a workplace mental health survey, employees might fear **judgment** or **job consequences** if their names are attached to responses.
2. **Reduces Social Bias**
   - When responses are **anonymous**, participants don't feel pressured to give **socially acceptable answers** instead of their true feelings.
   - **Example:** In political surveys, people might hide controversial opinions if they think their responses can be traced back to them.
3. **Protects Participants from Discrimination or Harm**
   - Some topics (e.g., sexual harassment, political dissent in restrictive countries) can put participants at **risk** if their identities are known.
   - **Example:** A survey on LGBTQ+ rights in a conservative country must be **anonymous** to protect respondents from discrimination.
4. **Increases Survey Participation Rates**
   - When anonymity is guaranteed, **more people are willing to participate**, leading to **better data quality**.
   - **Example:** A university's **substance abuse survey** will get more responses if students know their answers **won't be traced back to them**.
5. **Ensures Ethical and Responsible Research**
   - Many research ethics guidelines (e.g., **APA, IRB**) require **anonymity in sensitive surveys** to protect **participant privacy**.
   - **Example:** A mental health study collecting depression levels must ensure **patient identities remain confidential**.

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Common Ethical Issues in Survey Research

Issue	Description	Example
Survey Fraud	Faking responses	Employees filling out surveys themselves
Data Manipulation	Misrepresenting data for desired outcomes	Political polls altering results
Leading Questions	Questions designed to influence responses	"Don't you think our app is amazing?"

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Case Study :

- **Facebook's User Research Controversy (2014):**
  - Facebook manipulated news feeds to study emotional responses.
  - Users were **not informed**, violating **ethical guidelines**.
  - **Discussion:** Was this ethical? Why or why not?

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Assignment

•Find an example of a **bad survey** (e.g., biased wording, poor design).
•Write a **1-page critique** explaining why it is ineffective.

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